

Session 8: Ezekiel's Sign Acts

Key Takeaways

- Prophets deliver their message in more than words. Their bodies and lives are the medium for the message.
- Ezekiel symbolically bears the guilt of the people, mirroring the scapegoat in Leviticus 16.
- Part of the prophetic calling of Jesus' followers is periodic, intentional self-denial to bear witness to the brokenness in the world.

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 4:1-5:17

Sign #1: Brick City'

¹ And as for you, Son of a human ,
take for yourself a brick,
and set it before you,
and you will inscribe upon it a **city**, namely **Jerusalem**.

² And you will set up a **siege** against it,
and you will build a **siege-wall** against it
and you will pour out a **siege mound** against it
and you will set up camps against it
and you will place battering rams against it all around.

³ And as for you ,
take for yourself an iron plate
and you will set it as a wall of iron between you and between the city,
and you will set your face toward it
and it will be **under siege**,
and you will **besiege** it.
This is a sign to the house of Israel.

Sign #2: Lying Bound on the Side

⁴ And as for you ,
lay on your left side,
and you will place **the guilt of the house of Israel** upon it,
for the the number of days which you lie upon it, **you will bear their guilt**.

⁵ And **I will set for you the years** of **their guilt according to the number of days**:

three hundred and ninety days,

and **you will bear** the guilt of the house of Israel.

⁶ And you shall finish these,

then **you will lie a second time upon your right side,**

and **you will bear** the guilt of the house of Judah for **forty days;**

a day for each year I will set it for you.

⁷ And toward **the siege** of **Jerusalem** you will set your face

and your arm will be laid bare,

and you will prophesy against it.

⁸ And look, I will set cords upon you,

and **you will not turn from side to side** until you finish **the days** of **your siege**.

Sign #3: Eating Poop-Baked Bread

⁹ **And as for you ,**

take for yourself wheat and barley and beans and lentils and millet and spelt,

and you will put them into one pot

and you will make them into **bread**

for **the number of the days** which **you are lying on your side:**

three hundred and ninety days you will eat it.

¹⁰ And your **bread** which **you will eat,**

by the measure of a shekel, 20 shekels a day,

from time unto time **you will eat** it.

¹¹ And **you will drink** water by measure:

a sixth of a hin,

from time unto time **you will drink** it.

¹² And (as) cakes of barley **you will eat** it,

and you will bake it over piles of **human dung-balls** before their eyes.

¹³ And Yahweh said:

“In this way the sons of Israel **will eat,**

impure among the nations where I scatter them.”

¹⁴ And I said,

“Ack, Lord Yahweh!

Look, I have not become **impure,**

nor **have I eaten** what was **dead or torn by beasts** from my youth until now,

nor has **impure meat** entered my mouth!”

¹⁵ And he said to me,

“Look, I give you **cow’s dung instead of human dung-balls ,**

and you will make your bread over it.”

¹⁶ And he said to me,
“Son of a human,
look I am about to break the **supply of bread** in **Jerusalem**
and **they will eat bread** by measure and in anxiety,
and water **you will drink** by measure and in horror,
¹⁷ so that they might lack **bread** and water,
and they will be appalled at one another,
and will waste away in their guilt.

Sign #4: Shaving the Head and Beard

¹ And as for you, Son of a human,
take a sharp sword;
as a barber's razor take it for yourself,
and make it pass over your head and beard,
and take scales for weighing and divide it up.
² One third you will burn in the fire,
in the middle of the city as the days of the siege are fulfilled,
and you will take one third
and you will strike it with the sword all around the city,
and one third you will scatter to the wind,
and I will unsheathe a sword behind them.
³ And take a few in number from them,
and you will bind them in the edges of your robes,
⁴ and take again some of them,
and throw them into the fire,
and burn them in the fire;
from it a fire will go out to all the house of Israel.

Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
‘This is Jerusalem;
I have set her at the center of the nations,
and around her are the lands.
⁶ But she has rebelled against my ordinances more wickedly than the nations,
and against my statutes more than the lands around her,
for they have rejected my ordinances and have not walked in my statutes.’
⁷ Therefore, thus says Yahweh Elohim,
‘Because you have more turmoil than the nations around you,
and you have not walked in my statutes,
and you have not observed my ordinances,
even the ordinances of the nations around you, you haven't observed,’

⁸ therefore, thus says Yahweh Elohim,
‘Look, I, even I myself, am against you,
and I will perform judgments among you in the eyes of the nations,
⁹ and I will do among you what I have not done,
and the like of which I will never do again,
because of all your abominations.
¹⁰ Therefore, fathers will eat their sons among you,
and sons will eat their fathers;
for I will perform judgments on you,
and I will scatter all your remnant to every wind.

¹¹ ‘Therefore, as I live,’ declares Yahweh Elohim,
‘surely, because you have defiled my sanctuary
with all your detestable idols and with all your abominations,
therefore I will also withdraw,
and my eye will have no pity
and I will not spare.
¹² One third of you will die by plague,
and by plague they will come to an end among you;
and one third will fall by the sword around you,
and one third I will scatter to every wind,
and I will unsheathe a sword behind them.
¹³ And my anger will be finished,
and I will provide rest for my hot-anger,
and I will provide comfort for myself;
and they will know that I, Yahweh, have spoken in my passion,
when I have finished my anger among them.
¹⁴ And, I will make you a desolation and a reproach among the nations around you,
in the eyes of all who pass by,
¹⁵ and it will be a reproach, a reviling, a warning and an object of horror
for the nations around you,
when I perform judgments against you in anger, and in hot anger, and hot rebukes.
I, Yahweh, have spoken.
¹⁶ When I send against them the terrible arrows of famine,
which were for ruin,
which I sent to ruin you,
and I will add to the famine upon you,
and I will break your supply of bread,
¹⁷ and I will send famine and wild animals against you,
and they will bereave you of children;
plague and bloodshed also will pass through you,
and I will bring the sword on you.

The Sign Acts

Besieging the Brick City (4:1-3)

Ezekiel is to create a symbolic model of Jerusalem from a "brick" (לבנה, a recall of Babylonian bricks = big rectangle slab; see [Gen. 11:3](#)).

The scene symbolizes the siege of Jerusalem by Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon (see [2 Kgs. 24-25](#)); the "iron wall" symbolizes the separation between Yahweh and his people.

Laying on the Side (4:4-8)

Ezekiel becomes the suffering, prophetic priest and takes on the role of the scapegoat from the Day of Atonement (see [Lev. 16:21-22](#)), bearing the collective sin of Israel's apostasy.

"390 years" for Israel (either the northern tribes or the whole of the 12 tribes) probably refers to the entire period of the temple's existence (built by Solomon in the 970s-960s B.C.E.; see [1 Kgs. 6-8](#), roughly 390 years). Since this was the beginning of Israel's international apostasy through the monarchy and of the temple's defilement, it provides a temple period from Ezekiel's day back to the origin of the temple.

"40 years" could be (1) overlapping with the 390 years of the northern tribes, using the symbolic number for "a generation," that is, an entire generation of the exiles' sin (compare to the wilderness generation in [Num. 14:33-35](#)). Or (2) it could be added to the 390 years resulting in 430 years, which from Ezekiel's day would take the rebellion back to the period of David (note the number of 430 years for Israel's exile in Egypt in [Exod. 12:40-41](#)). Or (3) it could be a reference to the wilderness generation as a symbol of exile itself as a form of judgment.

Eating Rations and Impure Bread (4:9-17)

The barley bread recipe communicates two layers of meaning:

1. Barley was a lower quality grain than wheat, and so characterized the diet of lower class groups (see Greenberg, [Ezekiel 1-20](#), p. 107). This makes sense, as it describes the type of bread one can make when a city is under siege, that is, when there are no higher quality goods available.
2. The mode of baking, over human poop, is an image of a besieged city at as well. People can't go outside the town to poop, so the living (and baking) environments are defiled with excrement.

Ezekiel protests baking over human poop, as a sign of ritual impurity (see [Deut. 23:12-14](#)), whereas cooking over animal dung was more common.

Chopping the Hair and Beard (5:1-4)

Priests were prohibited from shaving their beards and hair ([Lev. 21:5](#); see also [Ezek. 44:20](#)), and it was a sign of extreme bereavement and mourning ([Isa. 15:2-3](#); [Jer. 16:6-7](#)). Ezekiel symbolically defiles his priesthood and enters into a state of public mourning.

“The hand that wields the sword is the hand of Yahweh, but the body being shaved is the house of Israel. The hacked body of Ezekiel is Israel—Israel being shorn of its priestly role among the nations, Israel being shattered in the grief of national defeat, Israel being shamed before those nations among whom she should have shone.”

Wright, Christopher J.H. (2001). [The Message of Ezekiel: A New Heart and a New Spirit](#). IVP Academic. 83-84.

Explanation of the Sign Acts

Israel's Covenant Election

In Ezekiel 5:5, “Jerusalem, which I have set in the center of the nations” reflects Ezekiel's theology of Israel's role in Yahweh's purposes for the nations ([Gen. 12:1-3](#); [Exod. 19:4-6](#); [Ps. 72](#)—Israel has utterly failed its mission).

Israel's Covenant Failure

Ezekiel 5:6-10 describes Israel's violation of Torah. “The laws and decrees” is a shorthand way of referring to all the commands of the Torah that embody the terms of the Sinai covenant (see [Deut. 4:6-8](#) and [Ps. 147:19-20](#)).

Ezekiel exploits the multiple nuances of the word “law” (*mishpat*).

- *mishpat* #1 = judicial acts that create a community of *tsedeq*
- *mishpat* #2 = standard/code of behavior
- *mishpat* #3 = acts of retributive judgment for the violation of *tsedeq*

Ezekiel 5:7-8 Instructor's Translation

You have not performed my *mishpat* (#1) you haven't even done like the *mishpat* (#2) of the nations around you. Therefore I am against you, and I will bring about *mishpat* (#3) in your midst before all the nations.

Israel is hyper-accountable for their apostasy because they have the Torah, yet they have failed in their priestly mission by behaving worse than the customs of the nations without Torah (see [Amos 3:1-2](#)).

The first mention of idolatry and defilement of the temple in Ezekiel 5:11 points forward to chapters 8-11.

Israel's Covenant Punishment

The covenant curses of [Leviticus 26](#) and [Deuteronomy 28](#) will fall on Israel.

- 5:10—cannibalism as a result of the siege = [Lev. 26:29](#)
- 5:10—“scatter you” = [Lev. 26:33](#)/[Deut. 28:64](#)
- 5:12—plague/famine = [Lev. 26:16](#)
- 5:12—open the sword = [Lev. 26:33](#)

- 5:14—public shame among the nations = Lev. 26:31
- 5:17—wild animals = Lev. 26:22

Israel's Covenant and the Nations

- 5:5—Nations were meant to see Israel's priestly witness to Yahweh
- 5:6-7—Nations provide a standard by which Israel is judged
- 5:8—Nations will witness Yahweh's justice visited on Israel
- 5:14-15—Nations will witness Israel's public shame

Israel's Covenant Hope

There is no hope mentioned in this passage, but the logic of the covenant in Leviticus 26 and Deuteronomy 28 was always that covenant violation and punishment would be followed by covenant restoration.

Reflection Question

In what way is the biblical practice of fasting similar to prophetic sign acts?